



Preschooler Attachment and Adolescent Psychological Flexibility

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Introduction

Psychological Flexibility

- Psychological Flexibility is identified as a Fundamental Aspect of Health Achieving psychological health by Kashdan and argues it is a central component to psychological health (2010).
- Broadly refers to being open, aware, and actively engaged (Hayes & Monestes, 2016).

Preschool Attachment Strategies

- The quality of the parent-child bond (Bowlby, 1969).
- Through this relationship, the child learns **(1)** compliance with requests, **(2)** Ability to regulate and communicate affect, especially negative affect (NICHD, 2004).

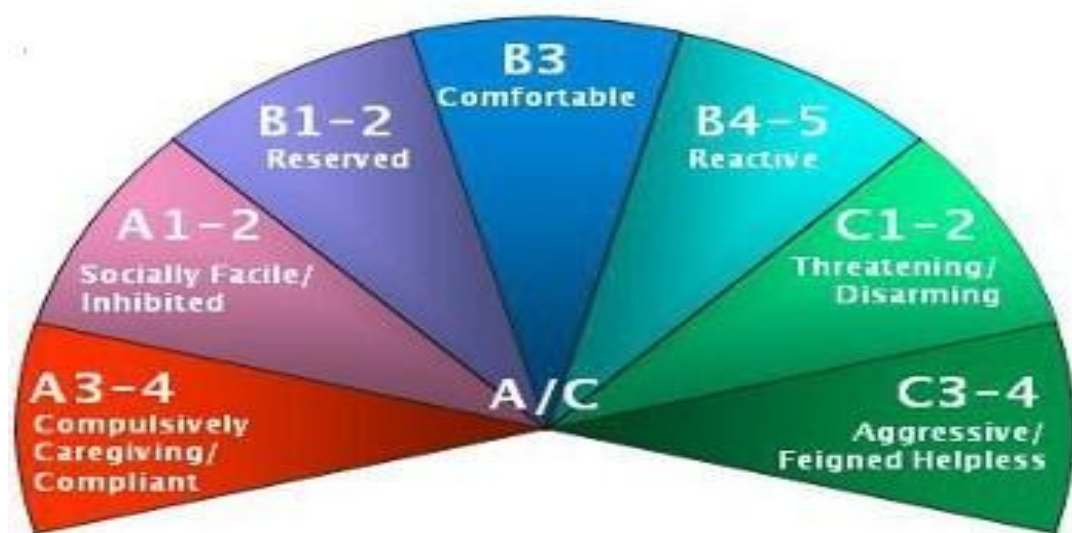
1. Secure: Caregivers are sensitive to child emotional cues and children tend to express both positive and negative emotions openly.

2 Avoidant: Caregivers either ignore or reject child cues of anger or vulnerability; thus, children tend to suppress such emotions.

3. Ambivalent: Caregivers attend more to helpless or angry behaviors than to positive behaviors. Children will tend to exaggerate their negative emotions because of this (Berlin & Cassidy, 2004).

▪ **Low Risk**=> B (or secure), and A1-2 through C 1-2

▪ **High Risk**=> A 3-4 and C 3-4
○ The further from B (or secure) in the model, the higher the risk (Crittenden, 2008).



Hypothesis

We predict that individuals with higher-risk preschool attachment strategies will show decreased psychological flexibility as adolescents.

Participants

This study is part of a longitudinal project that began when children were in preschool to examine the attachment relationships in Eastern Kentucky.

Subjects

- Participants were recruited from preschools serving predominantly Caucasian, low-income families.
- The sample in the 1st and 4th time of data included 21 adolescents (50% females).
- Participants were mean age of 4.5 years at time 1 and 16.5 years at time 4

Methods

Procedures

Strange Situation (SSP):

- A procedure intended to reveal patterns of caregiver-child attachment. The SSP used during time 1 includes a 25-minute process of reunions and separation (Ainsworth, Blehar, & Waters, 1978). The components of the SSP creates a stressful environment to prompt attachment behaviors.

- Subject considered low risk attachments:

➤ B = 5, C1-2 = 2, A1-2 = 2

- Majority of our subjects are high risk attachment

➤ A3-4 = 8, A/C, Dp, or IO = 5.

Self-Report Measures

- **Avoidance and Fusion Questionnaire for Youth (AFQY:** Greco, Lambert, & Baer, 2008)

- The AFQ-Y has 17 items answered on a 5-point Likert scale. Lower scores indicate greater psychological flexibility. Internal consistency with our sample was .85.

- **Social Desirability Scale – 17 (SDS-17:** Stöber, 1999, 2001)

- This 17-item T/F questionnaire measures willingness to admit imperfections. The higher the score indicates more defensiveness. Internal consistency for our study was .82

Results

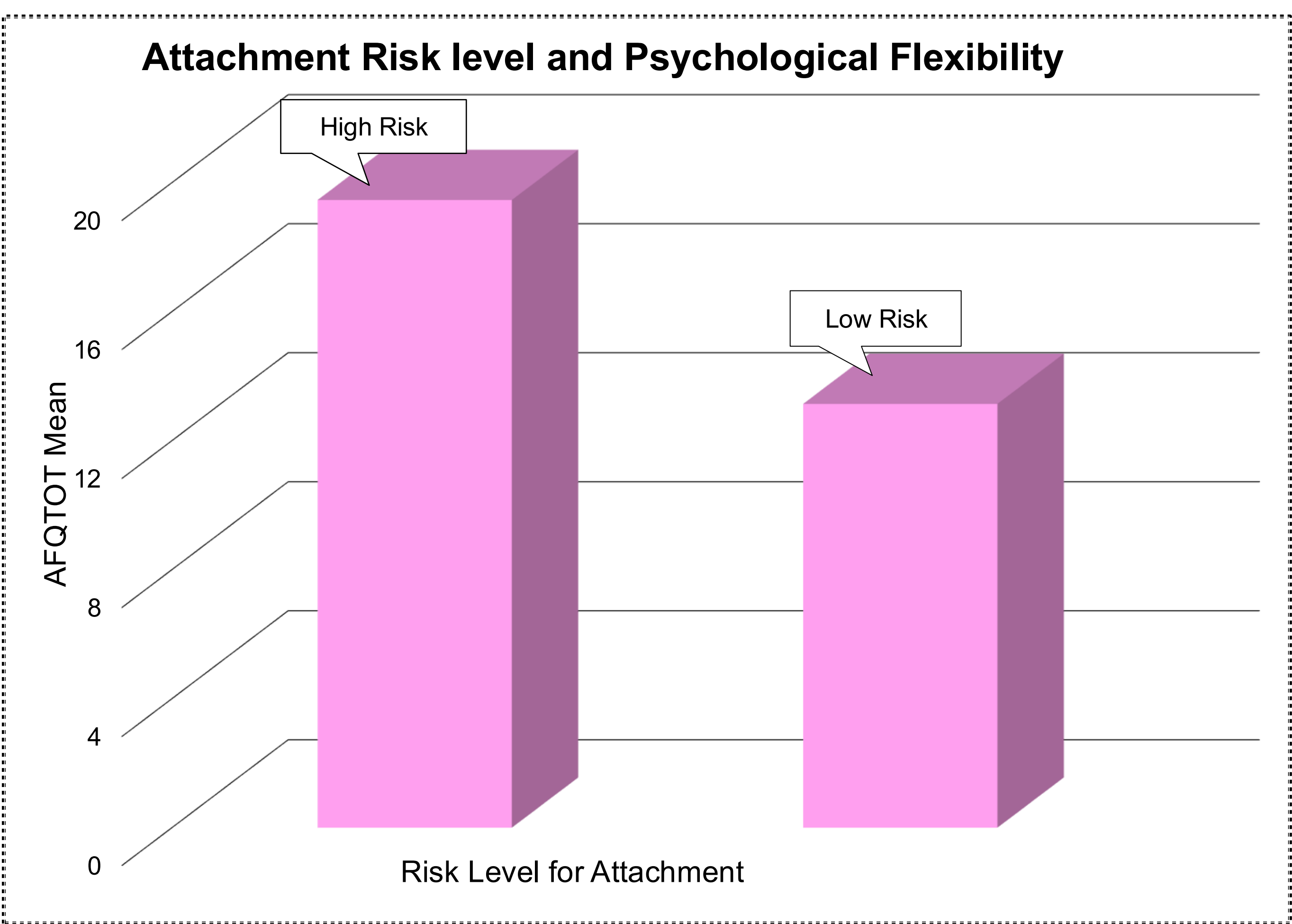
DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS

	High Risk Attachment	Low Risk Attachment
Mean	19.46	13.13
Standard Deviation	11.27	7.20
N	13	8

An ANCOVA was conducted to examine the association between the AFQY totals and preschooler attachment risk with SDS-17 as a covariate.

- preschooler attachment risk and psychological flexibility approached significance [$F(1,21) = 3.913$, $p = .063$, $\eta^2 = .179$].

Results



EFFECT SIZE

Coden D: 0.636

CI 95%: (-.275, 1.531)

- The effect size is between preschooler attachment risk and the AFQY totals without the covariate, SDS-17.
- There is medium to large meaningful relationship between the variables in our sample

Discussion

Explanation and Implication

- This is the first study that examines the relationship between preschooler attachment and psychological flexibility.
- The results were not statistically significant.
- This research is applicable to parent-child interventions.

Limitations

- small sample size
 - The insignificant results of Time 1 and 4 data may stem from the small sample.
- limited analysis of time 1 and 4 data due to time constraints.
- Given the effect size of sample size on statistical power, effect size provide an alternative method of examining these associations